

Week 1 Review and Feedback DRAFT

Year 11 Profile Course with Ms. Fernandez and Josh

November 22 2017

What Was Said

- **Clarity and Composition of Text:**
- **Reading vs. Lecturing vs. Examples:**
- **Getting Used to New Structures and Styles:**
- **Relevance to Life:**

What Remained Unsaid

- **What You Used the Hour For:**
- **Reflections on Learning:**
- **Questions You Asked Yourself:**
- **Questions You Want To Ask Us:**

What Should Have Remained Unsaid

Pattern: “*Today I/We Learned....*”: (eg. “Today we learned about a new thing!”)

Why: We all know what we are learning. (especially last week as we all had the same sheet!)

Instead: Today I spend most of my time understanding what a figurate number is: that is, a number that we can also depict as a shape that follows a specific pattern. I had never thought of numbers as shapes before today—we usually think of them as representing quantities or amounts of things (either discrete, like numbers of ducks, or continuous, like the amount of water in a glass) but this concept led me to also think of numbers geometrically.

Habits: Relevance is a super important factor in all future writing! In particular, we want to get into the habit of asking the following sets of questions:

“Who is my audience? What do they know? What do they need to know and how can I best explain it in a way that is as clear and complete as possible?”

“What does my next sentence seek to achieve? How does it relate to my previous sentence or current paragraph (or a higher level structure)? What question does this sentence really answer? (Usually we only answer *one* question per sentence—if you can do two in one, then you got lucky or, as is often the case for me—your sentence is too long!)

Pattern: “*I didn’t get it...*” (eg. “at first I didn’t get this new concept but then I read words and then magically I did!”)

Why: We never get things initially! If you read something and already “get it” then that means it didn’t challenge you!¹ Also, it tells us, as teachers, absolutely nothing when a student says “I don’t get it” if only for the reason that “it” is often unspecified, but also because it doesn’t give us any signal as to what specific part of that idea is unclear—usually the student *does* get it, there is just uncertainty or a feeling of insecurity.

Instead: If you initially didn’t understand something but then undertook some steps to learn that thing (even if one of those steps was asking a teacher or a neighbor) recording that process is super useful for both you and for your teacher!

Habits: There are three big habits here that we will talk about at length in other contexts: Grit², understanding your own learning process, self-diagnosis of what your own state of mind. All of these say that “not getting it” is just a temporary condition that precedes reflection, insight, and understanding.

Pattern: “*It/pronoun/general noun was good/bad/other adjective...*” (eg. “The notes were good, there were lots of words...”)

Why: Talking about things in general doesn’t really give anyone an indication of what you are talking about. On the one hand, that is safe—you wrote something but didn’t have to use your brain cells very much. In the end, it only hurts you as it lowers the quality of the feedback you give us and doesn’t give you any insight as to your learning process later.

Instead: I found the length of the notes daunting as I am not used to having to digest so many words in math class. English is not my first language so I found some of the words difficult, maybe I will try using my phone as a dictionary next time.

Habits: How we express ourselves is the single most important way we will be evaluated in most contexts in our personal and professional lives. Let’s let that sink in for a moment. It doesn’t get much more *Lebensnah* (English slang equivalent: “real”) than that! Many of you have wonderful vocabularies in multiple languages! If you want to write things in German that’s fine when it comes to the summaries (Josh hat kein Problem damit). If you struggle with vocabulary and literary means of self expression, this is an opportunity to practice! If you want to type these and send them via email that’s fine too! (Just please give us your hand written sketch in class and indicate that you will send us a digital copy. You can always take a picture of your sketch if you need it for later.)

This is a Learning Process

¹One might say that it did not conflict with any of your currently held mental representations... for more on this check out Dan Sperber and Deidre Wilson’s fantastic book *Relevance* (1986). They also have a great outline of the book for free online for those interested.

²Also known as vim, perseverance, Durchsetzungsvermögen, Mumm, Schneid... for some reason the shorter words sound better to me... In my family we also often speak of Sitzfleisch but I don’t have a good English translation of that one!